

I'll use the same exhaustive family-sweep standard as the fullest reference.

Word family: **letter / letters / lettered / lettering**

Base word: letter

Plural: letters

Verb forms: letters, lettered, lettering

Major related forms: lettered, lettering

Useful compounds/extensions: letterhead, letterform, letterbox, letter carrier, letter grade, letter of credit, letter of intent, open letter, cover letter, form letter, chain letter, varsity letter, four-letter word, dead letter

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞)

Your passage:

> "Your **letter** has the smell of roasted coffee, but also the weight of a real decision."

Meaning in this passage

Here, **letter** means **a written message sent from one person to another**, traditionally on paper, usually more substantial or formal than a short note.

繁體中文：

* **信** *

* **書信** *

* **來信** *

A natural translation:

> "Your **letter** has the smell of roasted coffee..."

「你的**來信**彷彿帶着烘焙咖啡的香氣.....」

The sentence is metaphorical: the physical letter does not literally have to smell of coffee. The writer means that its subject—the café dream—is vividly present throughout the message.

A. LETTER = WRITTEN MESSAGE

1. **letter = written message sent to another person (信 ; 書信)**

This is the exact passage sense.

> “I received a letter from my friend.”

「我收到朋友的一封**信**。」

> “She wrote him a long letter.”

「她給他寫了一封很長的**信**。」

2. **write a letter = 寫信**

> “He wrote a letter to the manager.”

「他寫了一封信給經理。」

Common grammar:

> **write a letter to someone**

3. **send / post / mail a letter = 寄信**

> “I mailed the letter yesterday.”

「我昨天把信**寄出**了。」

Regional preference varies between:

* post a letter

* mail a letter

4. **receive / get a letter = 收到信**

> “Did you receive my letter?”

「你收到我的信了嗎？」

5. **reply to / answer a letter = 回信**

> “She replied to the letter immediately.”

「她立即**回信**。」

6. **a letter from X / to X**

> “a letter from the bank”

「銀行寄來的信」

> “a letter to my parents”

「寫給父母的信」

B. PERSONAL / FORMAL CORRESPONDENCE

7. **personal letter = 私人信件**

A letter written primarily for personal rather than official/business purposes.

8. **business letter = 商業信函**

Formal correspondence concerning business matters.

9. **formal letter = 正式信件**

Typically follows conventional wording/layout appropriate to:

- * applications
- * complaints
- * institutions
- * business communication

10. **informal letter = 非正式 / 私人書信**

Usually written to someone personally known.

11. **handwritten letter = 手寫信**

12. **typed letter = 打字信件**

C. LETTER TO THE EDITOR

13. **letter to the editor = 致編輯的讀者來函**

A letter sent to a newspaper, magazine, etc. for possible publication.

> “She wrote a letter to the editor.”

「她寫了一封**讀者來函**給編輯。」

A major conventional compound.

D. COVER / APPLICATION LETTER

14. **cover letter = 求職 / 申請附函**

A letter accompanying:

- * résumé/CV

- * application

- * proposal

- * submission

explaining the sender's purpose and suitability.

15. **application letter = 申請信**

A letter formally applying for:

- * a job

- * a course

- * a position

* funding

depending on context.

16. **offer letter = 錄用 / 要約信**

Often in employment:

> written communication formally offering a job and outlining terms.

Can also occur in other transactional contexts.

17. **acceptance letter = 接納 / 接受信**

Confirms acceptance into:

* a programme

* institution

* position

depending on context.

18. **rejection letter = 拒絕 / 落選通知信**

E. RECOMMENDATION / REFERENCE

19. **letter of recommendation = 推薦信**

A letter supporting someone's:

* application

* ability

* character

* qualifications

20. **reference letter = 推薦 / 證明信**

Often overlaps strongly with **letter of recommendation**, although exact institutional conventions vary.

21. letter of reference

Alternative formal wording.

F. RESIGNATION / EMPLOYMENT

22. resignation letter = 辭職信

Written formal notice that someone intends to leave a job.

Very relevant to your passage thematically.

23. termination/dismissal letter = 解僱 / 終止僱傭通知信

Written notice ending employment.

24. appointment letter = 任命 / 聘任信

May formally appoint someone to a role or confirm employment, depending on institutional usage.

G. COMPLAINT / DEMAND

25. complaint letter = 投訴信

A written complaint to a company/institution/person.

26. demand letter = 正式要求函

Especially legal/business:

> a letter formally demanding payment, performance, action, etc.

It may precede litigation, but not every demand letter necessarily leads to court proceedings.

27. **cease-and-desist letter = 要求停止特定行為的正式函件**

A formal letter demanding that specified conduct stop.

Its precise legal effect depends on context and jurisdiction.

H. THANK-YOU / APOLOGY / INVITATION

28. **thank-you letter = 感謝信**

29. **apology letter = 道歉信**

30. **invitation letter = 邀請信**

Can be personal or formal/institutional.

I. LOVE / FAN LETTERS

31. **love letter = 情書**

A letter expressing romantic love/affection.

32. **fan letter = 粉絲信 / 仰慕者來信**

Written by an admirer to:

- * performer
- * writer
- * athlete
- * public figure

J. OPEN LETTER

33. **open letter = 公開信**

A letter addressed nominally to a particular person/group but intentionally published for a wider audience.

> “They published an open letter.”

「他們發表了一封**公開信**。」

K. FORM LETTER

34. **form letter = 套印 / 制式信件**

A standardized letter sent to many recipients, with little or limited individual customization.

Often used in:

- * administration
- * marketing
- * customer service

L. CHAIN LETTER

35. **chain letter = 連鎖信**

A message asking recipients to:

> copy/forward it to additional people.

Historically paper-based; similar behavior now often occurs electronically.

M. POISON-PEN LETTER

36. **poison-pen letter = 匿名惡意信**

A malicious, often anonymous letter containing:

- * insults
- * accusations
- * defamatory material

Old-fashioned but established.

N. DEAR JOHN LETTER

37. **Dear John letter = 絕交 / 分手信**

Traditional informal expression for a letter telling a romantic partner—historically often a serviceman—that the relationship is over.

Now somewhat dated/cultural.

O. LETTER BOMB

38. **letter bomb = 郵件炸彈**

A dangerous explosive device disguised/sent as mail.

This is an established lexical compound.

P. LETTER = ALPHABET SYMBOL

Now a completely different major branch.

39. **letter = one symbol of an alphabet (字母) **

> “A is the first letter of the English alphabet.”

「A 是英文字母表的第一個**字母**。」

This is one of the two most important base meanings.

40. **capital letter = 大寫字母**

> A, B, C

41. **small/lowercase letter = 小寫字母**

> a, b, c

42. **uppercase letter = 大寫字母**

More technical/computing equivalent of:

> capital letter.

43. **initial/first letter = 首字母**

> “The first letter of ‘coffee’ is c.”

44. **final/last letter = 尾字母 / 最後一個字母**

45. **silent letter = 不發音字母**

Example:

> **k** in *know*

is traditionally described as a silent letter.

46. **double letter = 重複字母**

Example:

> **tt** in *letter*

contains a doubled **t** spelling sequence.

47. **letter combination = 字母組合**

Examples:

* th

* sh

* ch

Though these may represent sounds in different ways depending on the word/language.

Q. LETTER ≠ SOUND

Important language-learning distinction:

letter

written alphabet symbol.

sound / phoneme

spoken sound/category.

One letter can represent multiple sounds:

> **c** in *cat* and *city*

and one sound can be represented by multiple letters.

So:

> **letter ≠ phoneme**.

R. LETTER ≠ CHARACTER

48. **letter vs character**

letter

alphabetic symbol such as A or b.

character

broader writing/computing term including:

- * letters
- * digits
- * punctuation
- * symbols

So every ordinary alphabetic letter is a character, but not every character is a letter.

S. LETTER ≠ GRAPHEME

grapheme

technical linguistic unit representing a contrastive element of a writing system.

letter

specific alphabetic symbol.

They often overlap in alphabetic systems but are not conceptually identical.

T. LETTER GRADE

49. **letter grade = grade represented by a letter (字母成績) **

Examples:

- * A
- * B
- * C
- * D
- * F

depending on grading system.

> “She received a letter grade rather than a percentage.”

「她收到的是**字母等級成績**，不是百分制分數。」

U. LETTER AS A MATHEMATICAL SYMBOL

50. **letter = alphabetic symbol used as a variable/label (字母符號) **

> “Let the letter x represent the unknown.”

「用字母 x 代表未知數。」

This remains fundamentally the alphabet-character sense, extended into mathematics.

V. LETTERS AFTER A NAME

51. **letters after someone's name = post-nominal abbreviations (姓名後銜) **

Example:

> professional or academic designatory letters after a name.

These may indicate:

- * degree
- * qualification
- * membership
- * honour

depending on convention.

繁體中文： ** 姓名後的資格 / 學位縮寫

W. LETTER = EXACT WORDING

A major abstract branch.

52. **the letter of a law/rule/agreement = exact literal wording (字面條文) **

> “He followed the letter of the law.”

「他嚴格遵守法律的**字面條文**。」

Here **letter** means:

> the exact written wording rather than broader purpose/intention.

X. LETTER VS SPIRIT

53. **the letter and the spirit** = 字面規定與精神 / 原意

Famous contrast:

letter

literal wording.

spirit

underlying purpose/intention.

> “They followed the letter but not the spirit of the rule.”

「他們遵守了規則的**字面要求**，卻沒有遵守其**真正精神**。」

Y. TO THE LETTER

54. **to the letter** = exactly; in every detail (完全按照；一絲不差)

Practice

> “Follow the instructions to the letter.”

「必須**一絲不差地**遵從指示。」

No alphabet meaning is intended directly in modern usage.

Z. LETTER-PERFECT

55. **letter-perfect** = exactly correct, especially memorized wording (絲毫不差的)

> “Her performance was letter-perfect.”

「她的表現**絲毫不差**。」

Originally associated with exact verbal/textual accuracy.

AA. DEAD LETTER — INEFFECTIVE RULE

56. **dead letter = rule/law/agreement that formally exists but is no longer effective (形同虛設的規定) **

> “The rule has become a dead letter.”

「這項規則已經**形同虛設**。」

Meaning:

> exists on paper but has little/no practical effect.

AB. DEAD LETTER — UNDELIVERABLE MAIL

57. **dead letter = undeliverable postal item (無法投遞的信件) **

A historically important postal meaning.

A **dead-letter office** handles mail that cannot be delivered or returned under the applicable postal system.

Same expression, different branch.

AC. LETTERS = LITERATURE / LEARNING

58. **letters = literature and literary scholarship (文學 ; 文藝) — formal/old**

Seen especially in:

> **a man/woman/person of letters**

59. **man of letters / woman of letters = literary scholar/writer (文人 ; 文學家) **

> “He was regarded as a distinguished man of letters.”

「他被視為傑出的**文人 / 文學家**。」

This does not mean:

> a man who writes lots of correspondence.

AD. BELLES-LETTRES

60. **belles-lettres = 純文學 / 美文**

A French-derived literary term traditionally referring to literature valued for aesthetic style.

Related to the **letters = literature** branch, though best treated as its own lexical item.

AE. REPUBLIC OF LETTERS

61. **Republic of Letters = historical intellectual community (文人共和國 / 學術書信共同體)**

Historical expression for the transnational community/network of scholars and intellectuals who exchanged ideas, especially in early modern Europe.

Priority: historical/specialist.

AF. LETTER = SPORTS AWARD — AMERICAN ENGLISH

62. **letter = school/college sports award (校隊字母獎章)**

In American school/college sports, athletes may receive a **varsity letter** recognizing participation/achievement.

> “She earned a letter in basketball.”

「她因校隊籃球表現獲得了**校隊字母獎章 / 資格**。」

Very culturally specific.

AG. VARSITY LETTER

63. **varsity letter = 校隊字母獎章**

Traditionally represented by a large school initial worn on clothing such as:

> a letter jacket.

AH. VERB: LETTER IN A SPORT

64. **letter in a sport = earn a varsity letter (取得校隊字母獎)**

American English.

> “He lettered in football and baseball.”

「他在美式足球和棒球校隊中都獲得了**校隊字母獎**。」

This is a genuine independent verb sense.

AI. LETTERMAN / LETTERWOMAN

65. **letterman = athlete who has earned a varsity letter (獲校隊字母獎的男學生運動員)**

Traditional American term.

Letterwoman also exists, though **letter winner / varsity athlete** may be more neutral alternatives in some settings.

AJ. LETTER JACKET

66. **letter jacket = 校隊字母外套**

Also:

> varsity jacket.

Traditionally decorated with a school letter/emblem.

AK. VERB: INSCRIBE WITH LETTERS

67. **letter something = write/paint/inscribe letters on it (寫字 / 刻字) **

Practice

> “The sign was carefully lettered by hand.”

「招牌上的字是仔細**手寫繪製**的。」

68. **letter a sign = 在招牌上書寫字樣**

> “She lettered the sign in gold.”

「她用金色為招牌**寫上字樣**。」

AL. **LETTERED = MARKED WITH LETTERS**

69. **lettered = bearing written alphabetic markings (標有字母 / 文字的) **

> “the lettered keys”

「標有**字母**的按鍵」

> “a hand-lettered sign”

「手工書寫字樣的招牌」

AM. **LETTERED = EDUCATED / LITERARY**

70. **lettered = educated, learned, especially in literature (有學問的 ; 有文化的) **

Formal/old-fashioned.

> “a highly lettered scholar”

「一位**博學的學者**」

This comes from:

> letters = learning/literature.

AN. LETTERING

71. **lettering = letters written/drawn/printed on something (字樣 ; 字體設計) **

Practice

> “The lettering on the sign was difficult to read.”

「招牌上的**字樣**很難看清。」

AO. HAND LETTERING

72. **hand lettering = 手繪字 / 手寫字體設計**

An artistic practice where individual letterforms are deliberately drawn rather than simply written as ordinary handwriting.

AP. LETTERING VS CALLIGRAPHY

lettering

letters are often **drawn/designed individually**.

calligraphy

letters are produced through controlled expressive writing strokes.

typography

arrangement/design/use of type.

There is overlap in creative practice, but the concepts differ.

AQ. LETTERFORM

73. **letterform = visual shape/design of a letter (字母形態) **

Typography/design term.

> the letterform of lowercase **g**

= 小寫 g 的字形設計.

AR. LETTER SPACING

74. **letter spacing = spacing between characters (字距)**

Typography/design/computing term.

Often distinguished from:

> word spacing.

AS. BLOCK LETTERS

75. **block letters = separately written printed-style letters (正楷 / 印刷體大字)**

> “Please write your name in block letters.”

「請用**正楷 / 清楚的印刷體字母**填寫姓名。」

Depending on region, this often implies uppercase or clearly separated printed letters.

AT. FOUR-LETTER WORD

76. **four-letter word = offensive/taboo word, stereotypically four letters long (四字母粗俗詞)**

> “He used several four-letter words.”

「他用了幾個**粗俗髒話**。」

Not every four-letter word is offensive, obviously; this is an idiomatic category.

77. **X is a four-letter word = X is treated as something disliked/taboo**

Humorous figurative extension:

> “For him, exercise is a four-letter word.”

Meaning:

> he strongly dislikes it.

The referenced word need not literally contain four letters in every humorous adaptation, though the idiom originates from taboo English words.

AU. RED-LETTER DAY

78. **red-letter day = especially important/happy day (值得紀念的大日子) **

Historically connected to important calendar days being marked in red.

> “Graduation was a red-letter day for the family.”

「畢業典禮是這個家庭值得紀念的**大日子**。」

AV. SCARLET LETTER

79. **scarlet letter = visible mark/symbol of shame or stigma (恥辱標記) **

Derived from the title/concept associated with Hawthorne's *The Scarlet Letter*.

In broader figurative use:

> a mark of social stigma.

Cultural/literary, lower priority.

AW. LETTERHEAD

80. **letterhead = printed heading on official stationery (信箋抬頭) **

Usually includes information such as:

- * organization name
- * logo
- * contact information

> “The letter was printed on company letterhead.”

「這封信印在公司的**正式抬頭信紙**上。」

AX. LETTERBOX — POSTAL

81. **letterbox = mail slot / box for receiving letters (信箱 / 郵件投入口) **

Especially BrE.

> “Put the envelope through the letterbox.”

「把信封投入**信箱 / 投信口**。」

AY. LETTERBOX — SCREEN FORMAT

82. **letterbox / letterboxing = display widescreen image with horizontal bars (上下黑邊格式) **

Film/video terminology:

> **letterboxed image**

has horizontal bars above and below the picture when preserving a wider aspect ratio on a narrower display.

The name derives from the long narrow shape of a mail slot.

This is an independently useful technical compound.

AZ. LETTER CARRIER

83. **letter carrier = postal delivery worker (郵差) **

Especially AmE.

Broader modern term:

> mail carrier.

BA. LETTER MAIL

84. **letter mail / letter post = ordinary correspondence category (信件郵件) **

Postal-service terminology distinguishing letter-type items from:

* parcels

* packages

Exact postal classifications vary.

BB. LEGAL / BUSINESS: LETTER OF INTENT

85. **letter of intent = 意向書**

A document stating one party's or multiple parties' intentions regarding a proposed:

* transaction

* agreement

* project

* application

Often abbreviated:

> **LOI**

Its binding effect depends on wording and applicable law; the title alone does not tell you whether it is legally binding.

BC. LETTER OF CREDIT

86. **letter of credit = 信用證**

A major trade-finance instrument in which a bank undertakes, subject to specified documentary conditions, to make/arrange payment under the applicable terms.

Common abbreviation:

> ****L/C**** or ****LC****

This is a genuinely independent financial compound.

BD. STANDBY LETTER OF CREDIT

87. ****standby letter of credit = 備用信用證****

A bank undertaking used as a form of payment/security support if the applicant fails to perform/pay according to specified terms.

Specialist finance.

BE. LETTER OF INTRODUCTION

88. ****letter of introduction = 介紹信****

A document introducing someone to another person/organization.

You encountered this under ****introduce****; it also belongs naturally in the ****letter**** compound family.

BF. LETTER OF AUTHORIZATION

89. ****letter of authorization / authority = 授權書 / 授權信****

Written document authorizing another person/entity to perform specified acts.

Exact legal effectiveness depends on purpose and jurisdiction.

BG. ENGAGEMENT LETTER

90. ****engagement letter = 業務委聘書 / 服務委聘信****

Common in professional services such as:

- * accounting
- * legal work
- * consulting

It sets out scope/terms of the engagement.

BH. COMFORT LETTER

91. **comfort letter = 安慰函 / 支持函 — finance/accounting**

A letter providing specified assurances or information without necessarily constituting the same obligation as a formal guarantee.

Its meaning/effect is highly context-dependent.

BI. SIDE LETTER

92. **side letter = 附帶協議函件**

A separate letter documenting additional or modified terms related to a main contract/agreement.

Whether legally binding depends on substance and applicable law.

BJ. LETTERS PATENT

93. **letters patent = 公開特許狀 / 專利特許文書**

Historical/legal term for an open formal instrument issued by sovereign/state authority granting:

- * office
- * right
- * status
- * patent

depending on legal system and period.

Note the conventional plural:

> **letters patent**

BK. LETTERS OF ADMINISTRATION

94. **letters of administration = 遺產管理授權書**

Probate/estate-law term in common-law systems for court authority appointing an administrator of an estate where applicable.

Exact procedure varies by jurisdiction.

BL. LETTERS TESTAMENTARY

95. **letters testamentary = 遺囑執行人授權文書**

In jurisdictions using this term, formal court documentation authorizing an executor to act for a deceased person's estate.

Specialist legal usage.

BM. LETTERS ROGATORY

96. **letters rogatory = 國際司法協助請求書**

Formal request from a court in one jurisdiction to judicial authorities in another for assistance in obtaining evidence or performing judicial acts.

Highly specialist.

BN. LETTER OF MARQUE — HISTORICAL

97. **letter of marque = 私掠許可證**

Historical government authorization permitting a private vessel/person to undertake specified hostile maritime acts against enemy shipping.

Historical/legal term.

BO. LETTER = WRITTEN CORRESPONDENCE COLLECTIVELY

98. **someone's letters = their collected correspondence (書信集 / 往來信件) **

> “The author's letters were published after her death.”

「這位作者的**書信集**在她逝世後出版。」

Here plural **letters** refers collectively to someone's correspondence.

BP. EPISTOLARY WRITING

99. **letter form / epistolary form = 書信體**

A story/essay can be written as letters.

Your current passage itself imitates an advice-letter format:

> “Dear Kam Chai...”

The genre/form is **epistolary** in structure.

BQ. IMPORTANT DISTINCTIONS

letter vs email

letter

traditionally a written/printed message, often physical.

email

electronic message.

An email may function like a letter, especially a formal one, but ordinary English normally calls it an **email**, not a letter.

letter vs note

note

usually shorter and less formal.

letter

usually more developed and conventionally addressed/signed.

- > short thank-you note
- > formal complaint letter

letter vs message

message

very broad:
spoken, written, electronic, brief, long.

letter

specific communication format.

Every letter conveys a message, but not every message is a letter.

letter vs mail

letter

one particular written item.

mail

postal material collectively, especially AmE.

- > "I received three letters in the mail."

letter vs correspondence

correspondence

written communication exchanged collectively.

letter

one individual communication.

> correspondence between two authors

> one letter from the collection.

letter vs memo

memo

usually internal organizational communication.

letter

typically communication addressed to another person/entity, often external.

letter vs notice

notice

communication whose function is to formally notify.

letter

format.

A notice can be delivered in a letter.

letter vs document

document

broad category of recorded information.

letter

specific communicative document genre.

BR. **LETTER OF LAW vs RULE**

Important conceptual distinction:

> **letter of the law**

does not mean:

> a letter/document sent by a lawyer.

It means:

> the exact wording of the law.

BS. GRAMMAR

100. **a letter to someone**

> “a letter to Kam Chai”

101. **a letter from someone**

> “a letter from Kam Chai”

102. **write someone a letter**

Double-object pattern:

> “She wrote me a letter.”

= 「她寫了一封信給我。」

103. **write a letter to someone**

Same meaning:

> "She wrote a letter to me."

104. **letter someone?**

The verb **letter** does **not normally mean "send someone a letter."**

So:

> *I lettered him yesterday* ❌

normally would not mean:

> I sent him a letter.

Use:

> wrote to him

> sent him a letter.

Modern verb **letter** chiefly means:

* inscribe letters;

* earn a varsity letter.

BT. COUNTABILITY

Correspondence

Countable:

> a letter

> three letters.

Alphabet character

Countable:

> one letter

> 26 letters.

Literal wording

Usually fixed singular:

> the letter of the law.

Literature/learning

Plural:

> letters

> a person of letters.

Sports award

Countable:

> earn a letter.

BU. FAMILY MAP

Family form / branch	Main meaning
-----	-----
letter — correspondence	written message sent to someone
letters — correspondence	collected/exchanged written correspondence
letter — alphabet	alphabetic character
letter — literal wording	exact wording rather than broader spirit
letters — literature	literary learning/writing; formal/older
letter — sports	American varsity award
letter — verb inscription	write/draw/inscribe letters onto something
letter — verb sports	earn a varsity letter
lettered — marked	bearing letters/lettering
lettered — learned	educated/literary; formal/old
lettering	written/drawn letterforms or their design

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
letter — message	寄給另一人的較完整書面信息；信 / 書信
write/send/receive a letter	寫 / 寄 / 收到一封信
letter to the editor	寫給報章 / 刊物編輯供刊登的讀者來函
cover letter	隨履歷 / 申請附上的求職 / 申請附函
application letter	正式申請工作、課程等的申請信
recommendation/reference letter	支持某人申請、證明能力 / 品格的推薦信

resignation letter	正式通知辭職的信	
complaint letter	正式提出不滿的投訴信	
demand letter	正式要求付款 / 履行 / 停止某行為等的要求函	
love letter	表達愛意的情書	
fan letter	仰慕者寄給公眾人物 / 創作者的信	
open letter	對指定人物 / 群體發出但公開供社會閱讀的公開信	
form letter	大量發送、內容標準化的制式信件	
chain letter	要求收件人繼續轉寄給他人的連鎖信	
poison-pen letter	通常匿名、帶惡意攻擊 / 指控的信件	
Dear John letter	告知伴侶結束感情的分手信；較舊式	
letter — alphabet	字母表中的一個字母符號	
capital/lowercase letter	大寫 / 小寫字母	
silent letter	拼寫中存在但在該詞讀音中不發音的字母	
letter grade	以 A/B/C 等字母表示的成績等級	
letters after a name	姓名後表示學位、資格、榮銜等的縮寫	
letter of the law	法律 / 規則的嚴格字面條文	
letter vs spirit	字面規定與真正目的 / 精神的對比	
to the letter	完全按照要求，一絲不差	
letter-perfect	文字 / 表演精確到幾乎毫無差錯	
dead letter — rule	名義存在但已失去實際作用的規定	
dead letter — mail	無法投遞或退回的郵件	
person/man/woman of letters	文學家、文人、文學學者	
varsity letter	美國學校因校隊參與 / 表現頒發的字母獎	
letter in a sport — verb	在美國校隊運動中取得 varsity letter	
letter a sign — verb	在招牌等物件上寫 / 畫字母或文字	
lettered — marked	上面標有字母 / 文字的	
lettered — learned	博學、有文學修養的；正式 / 較舊	
lettering	招牌、設計等上的字樣 / 字體繪製	
hand lettering	把每個字形當設計元素逐一手工繪製	
letterform	一個字母的具體視覺形態	
letter spacing	字母 / 字符之間的字距	
block letters	清楚分開書寫的正楷 / 印刷體字母	
four-letter word	傳統上指粗俗 / 禁忌英文詞語	
red-letter day	特別重要、值得紀念的日子	
scarlet letter	比喻公開的恥辱 / 污名標記	
letterhead	正式信紙頂部印有機構名稱、標誌、聯絡資料的抬頭	
letterbox — postal	收取 / 投入信件的郵箱或投信口	
letterbox — video	為保留寬畫面比例而在上下加黑邊的顯示形式	
letter carrier	郵政投遞員 / 郵差	
letter of intent	表明交易 / 合作等意向的意向書	
letter of credit	銀行按指定文件條件承諾付款的信用證	
standby letter of credit	在申請人未付款 / 履約時提供支持的備用信用證	
letter of authorization	書面授權他人進行指定行為的授權書	
engagement letter	專業服務中訂明服務範圍、條款的委聘書	
comfort letter	在特定商業 / 會計語境中提供有限支持或陳述的支持函	
side letter	與主合約相關、另行記錄附加 / 修改條款的函件	

letters patent	由國家 / 君主公開頒發特定權利、職位等的正式文書	
letters of administration	遺產程序中授權遺產管理人的法律文書	
letters testamentary	授權遺囑執行人處理遺產的法院文書	
letters rogatory	一地法院向另一司法地區請求司法協助的正式文書	
letter of marque	歷史上授權私人船舶對敵方船運採取指定行動的許可文書	
someone's letters	某人的書信往來 / 書信集	
epistolary form	以書信作為主要敘述形式的書信體	

For your original passage

> “Your **letter** has the smell of roasted coffee, but also the weight of a real decision.”

The exact sense is simply:

> **letter** = Kam Chai previously wrote a substantial personal message asking for advice about his career and café dream.

But stylistically, the writer gives the letter almost physical qualities:

> **smell of roasted coffee**

> → the café dream feels vivid and alive.

> **weight of a real decision**

> → the letter deals with a serious life choice.

So **letter** itself is literal; the predicates attached to it are metaphorical.

For your database, I would keep **6 major semantic cores**:

1. **written communication sent to another person**
2. **alphabetic character**
3. **exact literal wording — the letter of the law / to the letter**
4. **letters = literature, literary learning, correspondence**
5. **American sports award — varsity letter**
6. **verb: mark something with letters / earn a sports letter**

Then explicitly index the major lexicalized compounds **cover letter, open letter, form letter, letter grade, four-letter word, dead letter, letterhead, letterbox, letter of intent, letter of credit, letters patent, letters of administration**, because these have conventional meanings that cannot safely be reconstructed from a bare dictionary gloss such as 「信 / 字母」.